

Activating Joy Through Culturally and Historically Responsive Read-Alouds

Saba K. Vlach, Tova S. Lentz, Gholnecsar E. Muhammad

Educators can activate joy for their students during read-alouds by planning with the framework for culturally and historically responsive education that centers developing students' identity, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy.

Centering Joy

In this article, we center joy as a rigorous and serious pursuit in literacy education, particularly when it comes to engaging children in culturally and historically responsive education (CHRE). We came together as teacher educators (Saba and Gholdy) and teacher and literacy coach (Tova) to take our collective experiences in PK-12+ education and research to look at literacy development and texts that enable culturally and historically responsive literacies. CHRE is defined as practices that respond to the diverse histories, identities, literacies, and liberation of students and the social times we live in (Muhammad, 2023). In this approach, students develop five parts of their academic and personal development: identity, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy. Specifically, we emphasize joy in the context of engaging students with read-alouds. The following questions guide our writing:

- What is joy?
- Why does joy require our attention in literacy development?
- How has joy been defined by Black people historically? And how can these conceptualizations be useful for teachers today?
- How can read-alouds activate joy in a culturally and historically responsive educational (CHRE) framework?
- What are examples of CHRE read-alouds that center joy as an educational pursuit?

We believe joy has not been a prominent goal in the ways we cultivate the literacy development of our children in classrooms, yet when centering joy within instruction, literacy experiences can be enhanced and can prepare students for the world around them.

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Joy as a Response to Consciousness

While joy can be thought of as only something relating to celebrations, fun, or aspects of cultures like foods, holidays, or clothing, we know that history and scholarship teaches us that joy is much more. While these surface level ways of defining joy are still important, we want children to learn full and more complete ways to experience and embody joy. Musical artist and producer, Pharrell Williams, in the foreword of the book, *Unearthing Joy* (Muhammad, 2023), describes joy as “uninhibited, undistracted, euphoric. It means living free to define yourself and realizing your personal and professional dreams.” Here he connects joy to knowing yourself as well as developing oneself personally, academically, and professionally. Joy is a special enlightenment of one's heart and mind. When we learn and practice love of self and humanity, and care deeply for humanity and the earth, joy is enhanced. Joy encompasses sustained happiness, truth, beauty, aesthetics, art, wonder, personal fulfillment, and solutions to the social problems of the world (Muhammad, 2023). Joy is also recognizing the truth and voices of people who have been marginalized and historically excluded. It is also when educators bring art, music, poetry, and other creative texts into literacy experiences. This creates space for students' high levels of engagement, smiles, and interest in learning. When we elevate beauty in humanity and embrace truthful narratives and representations of diverse people of the world (including our students), we are creating spaces for students to be in the presence of joy in the classroom.

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Joy also has a special relationship to consciousness and justice—for there is no joy without justice. Joy can be fully experienced when we have an intentional effort and actions toward teaching children how to name, question, understand, and ultimately disrupt hurt, pain and harm in the world. For people of color, joy is an especially important and urgent pursuit because of efforts to erase Black, Brown, and Indigenous cultures in schools. We see this erasure throughout history (Love, 2019). Moreover, there remains a lack of diversity of people of color in children's literature and read-alouds (e.g., <https://www.cbsnews.com/video/why-diverse-childrens-books-are-important-tools-for-teaching-kids-about-themselves-and-others/#x>) and the histories and stories of people of color are often silenced or taught in false ways (e.g., Kohli et al., 2017). One cannot fully experience joy if hurt and harm are being inflicted. As long as there is injustice in the world, we must rethink literacy instruction to help children use their skills in ways that help them build a better world. We must not just think of literacy as reading, writing and language skills, but as the tools to resist harm, problem solve, and develop solutions. Joy is what we fight for in our lives and what our children will remember about their educational experiences.

Joy in Black Histories

When studying the history of joy among Black communities, joy was connected to the work of our ancestors as they strived to cultivate the heart, mind, and social action. The following are 10 Joy Lessons from Black History:

1. Joy is defined by one's truths, justice, problem-solving, anti-racism, and anti-oppression.
2. Joy is when we define abolition as education and education as abolition.
3. Joy is liberation and liberty for all.
4. Joy is connected to self-determination and self-empowerment.
5. Joy is when we center love, music, and art.
6. Joy is connected to justice and criticality.
7. Joy is present and experienced when learning is collective and collaborative.
8. Joy is enacted when young people's voices and truths are centered and shared.
9. Joy results from cultivating the mind and heart together.

10. Joy is healing from past and present societal harms. (Muhammad, 2023, p.69).

In this list, we see that the ancestors, who endured violence, pain, and suffering, worked toward abolition and liberation. They used their literacies to push against racism and oppression. Joy emerged when oppression was dis-

solved and abolished. Joy was also connected to the practice of (re)claiming self-determination and self-empowerment where they could create their own pathways in life, free from oppressive barriers. In doing so, they centered their artistry and artistic sensibilities and brought love, music, and art into their learning spaces. Joy was not about competing with one another or being self-centered; it was about collectivism. The ancestors always centered the educational needs of children; therefore, joy was focusing their

voices and perspectives in education. In many ways joy was how Black teachers educated their youth (Muhammad, 2022). Joy was also connected to social and emotional learning. The ancestors knew that one could not develop skills like decoding, fluency, and comprehension without connecting the learning to goals of self-awareness, cultural competence, relationship building, emotional intelligence, social awareness, empathy for others, resilience, compassion for others, and helping to advance the state of humanity. Therefore, texts were selected to pursue these goals. Finally, joy was connected to wellness, and healing so we do not replicate the same societal harms that inflicted our past. For us as educators, joy feels like wholeness, and we must help to cultivate children who are proficient readers, but who are also happy, thoughtful, and able to recognize beauty in themselves and around them. These concepts of joy are pursuits for classrooms, as history can help us to advance instruction today. Joy especially requires attention today because books, knowledge and Black histories are being banned in schools. Furthermore, teachers and students have pressures for test-prep and scripted curricula which can also disrupt joy. Joy is situated well in the culturally and historically responsive framework because as students are learning joy, they should also learn about who they are, about the cultural lives of diverse people, new skills, and a justice orientated education.

What is Culturally and Historically Responsive Education (CHRE)?

As stated in the introduction, the pursuit of joy is situated within the framework of culturally and historically responsive

PAUSE AND PONDER

- Beyond happiness, how do you define joy?
- How can you activate joy through read-alouds?
- Why is joy a "rigorous and serious pursuit" in the classroom?
- What kinds of joy do students experience in response to your teaching?

education. In studying literary traditions of 19th century Black Literary Societies in the Northeast, I (Gholdy) found that joy was cultivated through study, debate, community, and action (Muhammad, 2020). Drawing on the teachings of Black Literary Societies, my framework of CHRE (2020) has five pursuits for education: identity, skill, intellect, criticality, and joy. While the ways in which the pursuits are taught will vary depending on children's ages and the discipline area, each pursuit is a necessary layer of responsive instruction for students of all ages. The CHRE framework moves beyond theorizing literacy instruction as solely skills-driven and emphasizes other literacy goals needed for children's development. Giroux (2012) refers to skills-only instruction as "deadening pedagogy" with teachers serving as "technicians." Instead, we must position teachers as transformative intellectuals (Giroux, 2012). To move toward teachers as "transformative intellectuals" I (Gholdy) encourage educators to cultivate five goals of education:

1. **Identity**—teaching students so that they learn more about the self and others, helping youth to understand how content and instruction relates to students individually, and/or to a group or groups of people.
2. **Skills**—teaching students specific academic content and literacy proficiencies. This is traditionally the focus of American public schooling and is reflected in foundational guiding documents such as the Common Core State Standards.
3. **Intellect**—teaching students knowledge and creating spaces for them to apply their knowledge to the world. Intellect describes how content leads learners to a broader understanding of the topic, including its history. Deeper than the learning of discrete skills, the pursuit of intellect asks teachers to make clear the ways in which students can apply skills to learning about people, places, things, events, and new concepts.
4. **Criticality**—teaching students about justice and injustice, liberation and oppression, privilege, and power. Criticality relates to developing and maintaining a consciousness with which to observe good and harm in the world, and to take action to disrupt oppression. When children's criticality is developed and supported, they are empowered to trust their own thinking, informed by the world around them, to take steps toward a world that is more just.
5. **Joy**—teaching students about truth, happiness, peace, beauty, positive potential or impact, and/or strength associated with a topic.

In developing this framework, I asked teachers to consider the question, *How will you change as a result of your teaching?* In other words, it is key to encourage educators to

first assess their own sociocultural knowledge (Brown, 2010) and consider how their commitment to CHRE starts with themselves, specifically in the areas of justice and equity. Often, educators in the United States fear pursuing anti-racist and anti-oppressive education in the context of school due to their belief that schools are neutral and color-blind spaces (Love, 2019), and because of the onslaught of new policies that restrict teaching critical sociocultural and sociopolitical topics (Darling-Hammond, 2017). In response, educators avoid pursuing anti-racist and anti-oppressive education in order to remain *safe*. Despite these tensions, we insist that educators committed to enacting CHRE must begin with asking themselves such questions as:

- Who am I? Who am I not? Who do I desire to be?
- Am I an anti-racist educator? Do others recognize racial justice in me?
- What thoughts and ideals do I have that need disruption?
- Do I only care for people who share my beliefs?

Educators must engage in their own deep dive into unlearning as part of their enactment of CHRE and pursue their own empowerment before being able to make space for the empowerment of our young people. Learners must experience the first four pursuits of identity, skills, intellect, and criticality before they can experience joy as a state of consciousness and empowerment as these pursuits connect, work together, and build upon each other (Muhammad, 2020).

With these understandings of joy and CHRE, we next turn to the structure and practice of read-alouds as a welcoming and generative space to elementary school students and teachers as they learn CHRE literacies. We follow with practical instructional examples for five of the definitions of joy. For each selected definition of joy, we selected a sample read-aloud book. For each book, we present conceptual approaches for the five pursuits, and instructional ideas for before and after reading the text aloud. We end with a call for joy in literacy education, stressing the importance of making joy a central goal for learning in curriculum and instruction.

Read-Alouds and Joy

In a comprehensive literacy classroom, read-aloud is a predictable, routine structure in which the class gathers as a community to engage with and respond to a text. The central purpose of read-aloud is to make meaning as a collective. In the fields of literacy education and teacher education, scholarship concludes that with this structure teachers can focus on comprehension skills such as retelling, inferring,

and summarization (e.g., Fisher et al., 2004). Furthermore, foundational practitioner texts, such as Miller's *Reading with Meaning* (2012), recommend that teachers read texts aloud to their students every day in order to "emphasize all the thinking strategies" (2013, p. 37). We agree that read-aloud is a practice that enables elementary teachers to teach comprehension skills and thinking strategies. But we believe read-aloud can do much more.

Beyond the pursuit of skills in read-aloud, practitioners and scholars have studied the possibilities of multicultural read-aloud. In this practice, teachers strive to center the voices of the "Other"—people who "are traditionally marginalized in society, that is, that are *other than the norm*" (Kumashiro, 2001, p. 3). Scholars have also advocated for the use of multicultural children's literature (e.g., Fox & Short, 2003) or diverse texts (Thomas, 2016) written by cultural insiders (Henderson et al., 2020) as the primary teaching tool for enacting multicultural read-aloud. This kind of text can serve as a pedagogical resource that offers multiple perspectives, "challenges the canon" (Cai & Bishop, 1994, p. 69), and "supports diversity and raises consciousness on issues ignored in school" (Perini, 2002, p. 428).

Educators need more than multicultural texts (e.g., Enriquez, 2021; Vlach, 2022). Despite using diverse texts during read-alouds, teachers often share these texts in order to center the oppression communities have endured at the hands of the dominant group. In our society, teaching about the *Other* tends to begin with their victimhood (e.g., Adichie, 2009; Busey & Walker, 2017; Kumashiro, 2001), rather than their resistance and triumph (e.g., Edwards, 2015; Rizzuto & Steiner, 2022; Toliver, 2020; Vlach, 2022). To center the agency of the *Other*, teachers need to ask themselves critical questions about their own knowledge and positionality, as we outlined previously. In another study I (Saba) (2022) concluded that when critical in-service elementary educators developed transformative read-aloud curricula and facilitated daily discussions in response to multicultural texts that disrupted "dominant narratives of meritocracy, neutrality, and colorblind ideology" they changed "the underlying story of the United States for their students" (p.41). As we strive to activate joy during read-alouds, we return to the genius of Black teachers, families, and communities historically, and we (re)consider the possibilities of learning through read-aloud with the pursuits of the CHRE framework.

We are reminded in *Cultivating Genius* (2020) and *Unearthing Joy* (2023) that when Black, Brown, Indigenous folx across all abilities tell their stories, they begin their stories with joy. In this article, we suggest that to activate joy, educators must start with stories that center and celebrate our young people, their lived experiences, and their histories from a place of self-empowerment. We know that when educators share stories, they choose where those stories will

start. In culturally and historically responsive read-alouds, educators need to make a shift away from starting with oppression and violence, and instead situate their read-alouds in joy. If educators ultimately desire for their students to experience joy as we have defined in this article, then they must offer joy and genius in the stories they curate for their classroom read-alouds. As teachers center joy in teaching and learning, particularly with read-alouds, they must ask:

- What read-aloud have we selected as a classroom?
- How might the read-aloud help my students learn more about their lives (identity), literacy proficiencies (skills), new knowledge (intellect), justice, problem solving and equity (criticality) and truth, solutions, and beauty (joy)?
- How does the read-aloud (including layered texts, teaching materials, and learning experiences) elevate beauty and joy?
- What forms of beauty, truth, justice, happiness, or benefits appear in what I am teaching? What type or form of joy am I teaching and why? Why do students need this type or form of joy? Why now?
- How will I write learning pursuits that will help my students pursue and embrace joy?
- How do open and convey the joy of Black people and others who have been historically excluded, marginalized, oppressed, misrepresented, or underserved?
- How do I tell the truth and genius about Black people and others who have been historically excluded, oppressed, misrepresented, or underserved?

With these guiding questions, teachers can begin to transform their read-aloud curriculum and practice. When educators are brave enough to move away from the skills-only literacy curriculum and open their instruction to the pursuit of joy, they will guide their students toward a critical love of self and community.

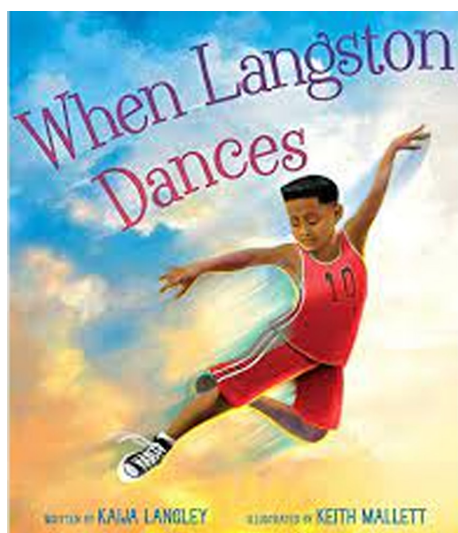
Practical Examples of Culturally and Historically Responsive Read-Alouds that Center Types of Joy

In this section, we provide examples for five of the ten lessons of joy from Black History. We present a read-aloud text, a picture-book, that is representative of the joy lesson. For each example, we provide a grade-level range, five pursuits, and activities for before and after the read-aloud. We have articulated the five pursuits for each example lesson in the form of questions. We envision these questions as guiding questions that teachers might ask their students during read-aloud. It is not our

intention for teachers to enact these lessons in a single day during a single reading of the text. Instead, we encourage teachers to consider the time they will need to adequately engage their students in the read-aloud practice with these texts in order to activate joy.

Example #1: Joy as Centering Love, Music, and Art

Read-Aloud: *When Langston Dances*, by Kaija Langley (author) and Keith Mallett (illustrator) (Kindergarten–2nd Grade)



Before Reading:

- Have prepared a piece of chart paper labeled “Types of Dances,” tape, markers, and photographs of different kinds of dance, with captions labeling the dances. Examples include tap, ballet, jazz, modern, and hip hop. Ask students what kinds of dances they know. If students share one of the dances you have a photograph of, tape the photograph to the chart. If not, write the type of dance on the chart, leaving space to add a picture later. Explain that you are going to read a book about ballet.
- Tell students that Alvin Ailey is a professional dance group. Watch a video of Alvin Ailey dance, *Four Corners*, choreographed by Ronald K. Brown (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wR8aDe_mtbE).

During Reading Guide with Pursuits:

- **Identity:** Langston wears ballet slippers and a basketball jersey and shorts to dance in. What do you wear to feel comfortable or be able to dance or move?

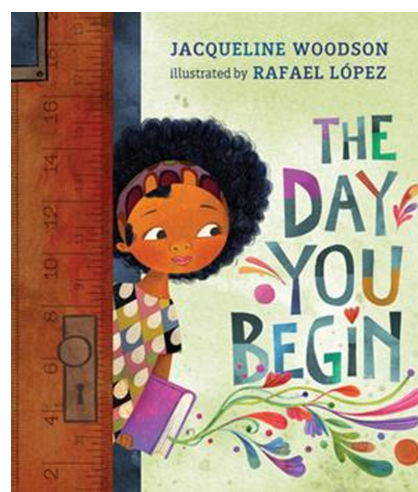
- **Skills:** What do the illustrations tell you about how Langston feels whenever he is dancing? (RL.K.7, RL.1.7, RL.2.7)
- **Intellect:** What is a stereotype? How does it limit the way we think about each other?
- **Criticality:** When another child says, “Boys don’t dance like that,” Langston replies, “They do too. I’ve seen them!” What would you do if someone says that a group of people is not allowed to or should not do something? Why is it important to speak up when you hear a stereotype?
- **Joy:** What kind(s) of dance would you like to watch? What kind of dance looks fun to try?

After Reading:

- Ask students if they know what a stereotype is. Allow students to share and ensure a common understanding. See “Explore Stereotypes” in *Start Here Start Now* (Kleinrock, 2021, p. 32–35) for a detailed example. Reread the stereotype stated by a character in *When Langston Dances*: “Boy’s don’t dance like that.” Ask how that stereotype can limit the way we think about dancing and boys.

Example #2: Joy as Centering and Sharing Young People’s Voices and Truths

Read-Aloud: *The Day You Begin* by Jacqueline Woodson and Rafael López (illustrator) (1st–3rd Grade)



Before Reading:

- Define and discuss identity. Ask students to complete identity webs and/or engage in a “Who are you?” activity (Muhammad, 2020). For this activity, students talk in pairs: the first partner asking, “Who are you?,” over

and over, the second partner responding with a different answer each time. After a minute, partners switch. Debrief, asking students to reflect on what was personally easy about the activity, what was challenging, and their overall impressions. Support students in understanding that identity is multifaceted, that there are many aspects that make us who we are.

- Ask students what creating space means. Add ideas to the top of a piece of chart paper.

During Reading Guide with Pursuits:

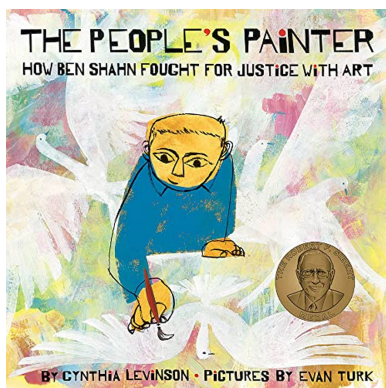
- **Identity:** What parts of your story do you want to share?
- **Skills:** How would you describe Angelina? (RL.1.3, RL.2.3, RL.3.3)
- **Intellect:** What does it mean to create space for yourself? Why is it important for everyone to have space?
- **Criticality:** Angelina creates space for herself by starting to share her story. What other ways can people create space for themselves?
- **Joy:** How can creating space lead to joy?

After Reading:

- Ask again what it means to create space. Add new ideas to the chart created before reading. Ask how people can create space. Add these ideas to the bottom of the chart.
- **Extension:** Read the co-created list of ideas about how to create space. Work with students to identify an idea they can turn into action, either in groups or as a class. Provide support for students to do so.

Example #3: Joy as Justice and Criticality

Read-Aloud: *The People's Painter: How Ben Shahn Fought for Justice with Art* by Cynthia Levinson (author) and Evan Turk (illustrator) (4th–5th Grade)



Before Reading:

- Show students Ben Shahn's paintings and photographs. Invite students to discuss what they see in the artwork and note any questions they may have.
- Show students the Hebrew alphabet, discussing similarities with and differences from the Roman alphabet (the alphabet used by many languages, including English). Tell students that Hebrew is read from right to left.
- **Teacher's note:** A little more than halfway through the book, the text states, "He painted other stories about outsiders: working people, prisoners, and Jews who had been mistreated." Before reading, discuss with students that language has been and can be used as an othering mechanism, an insult with impact, creating and maintaining stereotypes about groups of people. Sometimes, referring to a group of people with the plural -s, such as "Jews," elicits those negative connotations and can be offensive to people within that group, who may prefer an adjective descriptor, such as "Jewish." Sometimes, people within a given group use plural -s terms with pride. Different people will have different preferences in different contexts. It is important to have this awareness, especially if you are not a member of the group being described. Remind students of this discussion when it comes up in the book.

During Reading Guide with Pursuits:

- **Identity:** What message is important to you that you want to share with other people?
- **Skills:** What events and ideas led Ben Shahn to create art? (RI.4.3, RI.5.3)
- **Intellect:** What does justice mean? What examples of justice and injustice do you see in the world?
- **Criticality:** In addition to creating art, what other ways can people stand up for justice?
- **Joy:** How can art be liberating? How is justice connected to love?

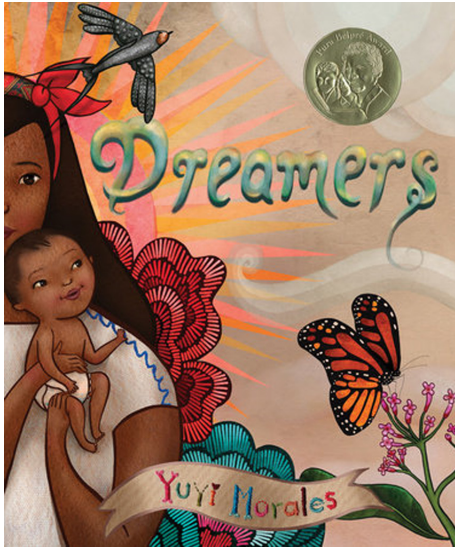
After Reading:

- Revisit Ben Shahn's paintings and photography students talked about before reading. Have students discuss what they see in the artwork, having read the book, and ask if they have any new thinking to respond to their earlier questions. Note any new questions that arise.
- Students can create art to communicate about something they believe in. Students can share their pieces among the class, and/or set up an art gallery in their

classroom and invite other classes, teachers, caregivers, and/or community members to visit.

Example #4: Joy as Self-Determination and Self-Empowerment

Read-Aloud: *Dreamers* by Yuyi Morales (author & illustrator); (2nd–5th Grade)



Before reading:

- Share with students author Yuyi Morales' "My Story" at the back of *Dreamers*. Display a map showing Ciudad Juarez, Chihuahua, where she left Mexico, and El Paso, Texas, where she crossed into the United States.
- Teach/discuss the following vocabulary, noting the words in both Spanish and English; you can listen to the pronunciation online to ensure you are correctly saying any words that may be unfamiliar to you: amor/love, inmigrantes/immigrants, migrantes/migrants, caminantes/walkers, improbable/improbable, lucha/fight/struggle, soñadores/dreamers

During Reading Guide with Pursuits:

- *Identity*: What hopes or dreams do you have for the future?
- *Skills*: What is the message or theme in *Dreamers*? (RL.2.2, RL.3.2, RL.4.2, RL.5.2)
- *Intellect*: What does immigrant mean? What are some reasons that people immigrate?
- *Criticality*: How did the main character empower herself?
- *Joy*: How can libraries and stories bring people joy?

After reading:

- Ask, "What actions can you take to make someone feel welcome?" Record responses on chart paper, and refer to it throughout the year when relevant, such as when discussing immigration or welcoming a new student.
- Visit a class, school, or community library, or bring books in from a library to share with students. Reread the pages in *Dreamers* about the library and books, when the main character describes what books mean to her and her child. Have students look through the library books, identifying a book that they "trust," is their "language," is their "home," and/or is their "lives." Allow students time to read and share the books with each other.

Example #5: Joy as Healing

Read-Aloud: *See Us Bloom*, by Kyunghee Kim (author) and Emily Paik (illustrator) (1st–3rd Grade)



Before Reading:

- Show a feelings chart. Invite each student to share, along with the teacher, how they are feeling. This can be a regular practice in your classroom, such as during a morning meeting, after lunch, or following another transition time.
- Ask students how they take care of themselves and each other. List their responses on chart paper.
- Teacher's note: This book is both a collection of poetry and a narrative, the poems complemented by the illustrations. You can read this book all the way through with your students, discussing along the way the

story being told by both the poems and the pictures. Throughout the year, you can reread poems from the book individually; the poems' various themes support everything from living with change (*We Can Become Friends with Change*, p. 6) to self-advocacy (*We Are Brave When We Say No*, p. 8) to personal growth (*We Are Growing Every Day*, p. 21) and more.

During Reading Guide with Pursuits:

- **Identity:** How do you feel? How do your feelings change throughout the day or when you do new things?
- **Skills:** How did Ba-Da's feelings change throughout the book? Why did they change? (RL.1.1, RL.2.1, RL.3.1)
- **Intellect:** What is self-care? How is it related to bravery?
- **Criticality:** Why is self-care important? What are some ways people take care of themselves?
- **Joy:** What self-care practices would you like to try?

After Reading:

- Ask students again how they take care of themselves and others. Reread the chart co-created before reading and invite any new ideas.
- Reread *We Are Brave When We Say No* (p. 8). On chart paper, draw a line vertically down the middle. On one side, write, "No." Ask students what they say no to. List their responses. On the other side, write, "Yes." Ask students what they say yes to, listing their responses. Discuss how students can take action to say "no" or "yes." Say that sometimes, what people say "no" and "yes" to changes over time. Display the chart and make any edits or additions throughout the year as needed to reflect students' current "nos" and "yesses."
- Extension: After making the above no/yes chart, have students pick something they say "no" or "yes" to, and draw, write, or explain aloud what they chose. This gives students the opportunity to practice using their voice to take care of themselves.

As educators consider these examples of culturally and historically responsive read-alouds, we offer key reminders for educators as they prepare to develop their ownw culturally and historically responsive read-aloud curricula. First, it is important to remember that although practitioner texts may recommend that we read-aloud a different book each day with our students, we cannot effectively teach all five pursuits with one text in 1 day. Teachers will have to slow down and consider how many days they will need to plan to provide space and time for students to engage with all five pursuits. Next, as we stated early in the article, the work of activating and pursuing joy is about being active in our

TAKE ACTION!

1. Familiarize yourself with the 10 Joy Lessons from Black History
2. Review Muhammad's framework for Culturally and Historically Education and the Five Pursuits
3. Remember: It starts with the self! Take time to reflect on the following questions: *Who am I? Who am I not? Who do I desire to be? What racist, sexist, discriminatory beliefs have been conditioned inside of me from family, community, and society?*
4. Keep in mind: *Joy has a special relationship consciousness and justice, for there is no joy without justice.*
5. For the daily read-aloud, reimagine where to start the story of liberation. Reflect: *Should we start with oppression? Or should we start with resistance and self-empowerment? We start from a place of humanity, celebration, and joy.*
6. Read books by diverse authors and illustrators. Curate multimodal layered text sets.
7. Plan for before, during, and after your read-aloud.
8. Remember, comprehension skill instruction is only $\frac{1}{5}$ of the pursuits.
9. Develop your 5 pursuits for your read-aloud text(s).
10. Remember, culturally and historically read-alouds take place over days.
11. Activate Joy for your students and yourself through listening carefully to the stories of joy in the texts you share.

own commitment to learning across the five pursuits. In this sense, educators who teach with CHRE as their framework must be committed to their own unlearning and learning on issues of identity, intellect, and criticality. It is clear to us that if educators are not practicing and performing well in the areas of the five pursuits themselves, then it will be difficult to teach them. And finally, with the five examples of culturally and historically responsive read-alouds provided, we encourage educators to make these their own by planning further strategies and methods to activate joy in their students.

Activating Joy

With the above examples, joy has the potential to be activated. We use the word, "activate" intentionally because it carries energy and action. For us, read-alouds are wonderful opportunities not only to engage the energies of our students' genius and joy but to also move them toward social action. We believe that joy should always be a pursuit in the context of literacy education in the elementary classroom

and literacy practitioners can begin their work toward the pursuit of joy by planning and enacting read-alouds that build on all five pursuits – starting with teaching for identity and ending with activating joy. We cannot move to joy by only learning (or teaching) skills. The pursuit of skills needs to be embedded in a larger movement toward becoming global citizens. With read-alouds, there is space for students and teachers to co-construct knowledge because culturally and historically responsive read-alouds provide all participants a seat at the table to listen to stories from multiple perspectives. As we listen to more stories together, we can learn to accept that there will always be more layers and more voices for any story. Teachers can begin their journey toward joy by activating joy for their students and themselves during their daily read-aloud practice.

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The authors have no conflicts of interest to disclose.

Correction statement. This article has been updated since publication on 5 May 2023. The following changes were made:

- In the description of Identity, “teaching students in ways where they learn” was replaced with “teaching students so that they learn”
- In the description of Skills, the apostrophe from “students’” was removed.
- In the description of Intellect, the apostrophe from “students’” was removed.
- In the description of Intellect, “the ways on how to apply skills” was replaced with “the ways in which students can apply skills”
- In Read-Alouds and Joy, “balanced” was replaced with “comprehensive”; “with” was added after “engage”; “in” was added after “situate their read-alouds”
- In the Practical Examples section, the comma after “framework” was removed; “areas of the five pursuits” was replaced with “areas of the five pursuits themselves”

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- Social Justice Books Booklists: <https://socialjusticebooks.org/booklists/>
- Lee & Low: Classroom Library Questionnaire: https://www.leeandlow.com/uploads/loaded_document/408/Classroom-Library-Questionnaire_FINAL.pdf
- Learning for Justice: Social Justice Standards: <https://www.learningforjustice.org/frameworks/social-justice-standards>
- The Textual Lineage Tree https://www.scholastic.com/pro/reachteachlanding_dr_gholdy_muhammad.html
- A Handful of Quiet: Happiness in Four Pebbles, by Thich Nhat Hanh (2008)